

Sara Melchionda

MA Candidate
Prospective PhD Researcher

📞 Contacts

🌐 <https://saramelchionda.github.io/>

✉️ sara.melchionda@edu.unito.it

📖 Spoken Languages

Native Italian

Advanced English CEFR C1

Cambridge Assessment English

🛠 Skills

- Proficient in **Stata** and **R** for social research
- Developing proficiency in **Python** for data scraping and NLP tasks
- Use of **LLMs** and **BERT** for automated text analysis
- Knowledge in **extracting** and **managing** large datasets
- **Adobe** Suite (Photoshop, Premiere, After Effects)

🎮 Interests

Digital cultures, video games, and professional multimedia content editing

👤 About Me

- MA Candidate in Public and Political Communication with a strong focus on **Computational Social Science**. My research specializes in the analysis of **online political extremism** and **conspiracy narratives**. I am currently developing an experimental thesis utilizing **Large Language Models** and **BERT** to detect sarcasm and radicalization dynamics within anonymous digital communities. Proficient in **quantitative data analysis** and digital research methodologies.

📋 Research & Academic Experience

- **CODER Lab - University of Turin**
Research Collaborator Present
Contributing to an **academic project** utilizing LLMs to classify **political discourse** on **complex dimensions** (e.g., populism), advancing data-driven **content analysis** techniques within the lab.
- **Master's Thesis Project** Present
Developing an experimental framework to analyze online conspiracy discourse on Reddit. I am testing the performance of **BERT** and **LLMs** in decoding **vernacular internet slang and sarcasm**, aiming to identify and correct **measurement biases** inherent in traditional dictionary-based methods.
- **CONSPIRE Project (EU-Funded)**
Research Participant Present
Actively participating in an **international research project** focused on the dynamics of **conspiracy theories**. The activities include theoretical seminars and role-playing simulations designed to model and study the mechanisms of **radicalization and misinformation** spread within digital environments.
- **Advanced Methodology Labs**
Data Analyst Trainee 2024 - present
Big Data Analysis: Acquired advanced skills in managing **large datasets**, focusing on the **social implications** of algorithmic sorting and digital traces.
Stata & R Lab: Developed proficiency in **quantitative data management**, **econometric modeling**, and **statistical inference** for social sciences.
Collegio Carlo Alberto Lab: attended a high-level specialization lab on **advanced research design** and **social complexity**.

🎓 Education

- **Master's Degree in Public and Political Communication**
University of Turin 2024 - ongoing
Focus on Computational Social Science and data-driven political analysis. High-achieving record in core methodological courses, including **30/30 cum laude** in Quantitative Methods and in Polls, Media & Public Opinion, and **30/30** in Big Data & Methods for Content Analysis.
- **Bachelor's Degree in Intelcultural Communication**
Università di Turin 2021 - 2024
Graduated with a thesis titled: "How the linguistic approach on queer and gendered themes in TV series has changed: a focus on Grey's Anatomy". The project, written and discussed in English, analyzed **linguistic shifts** and **media representation** through a **sociolinguistic lens**.
- **Diploma in Audiovisual and Multimedia Production**
IIS M. Buniva 2017 - 2021
Final grade: 100/100. Developed foundational technical skills in **digital media production** and **multimedia editing**.